IPA
AN FORAS RIARACHÁIN
INSTITUTE OF PUBLIC
ADMINISTRATION

Certificate in Local Government Studies
(Accredited by NUI)

LESSON 2
Local Government Reform

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Institute of Public Administration

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Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should able to:

- Give and account of reports and legislation on local government reform.
- Outline current developments and local government reform programmes.
- Appreciate the current emphasis on modernisation and customer service.

2.0 INTRODUCTION AND OVERVIEW

Since the 1960s, a plethora of reports have appeared proposing reform measures for the Irish local government system. The principles contained within the Barrington Report (1991) proved particularly influential on official thinking towards the sector. This report noted the absence of reform of the system, lack of integration of services at local level, the narrow range of services for local authorities and the limited local taxation system. It recommended devolution of central government functions to the local level in education, transport, policing and community care among others, in line with the principle of subsidiarity. It also advocated the need for local taxation with accountability and limiting the post of chief executive (then called the county / city manager) to 10 years. This was a more visionary approach to local government reform than previous reviews, and it influenced the resulting government strategy, *Better Local Government* (1996), and the 1991 and 1994 Local Government Acts. Subsequent policy responses were designed to renew and strengthen a local government system facing *systemic* challenges at the start of the new millennium.

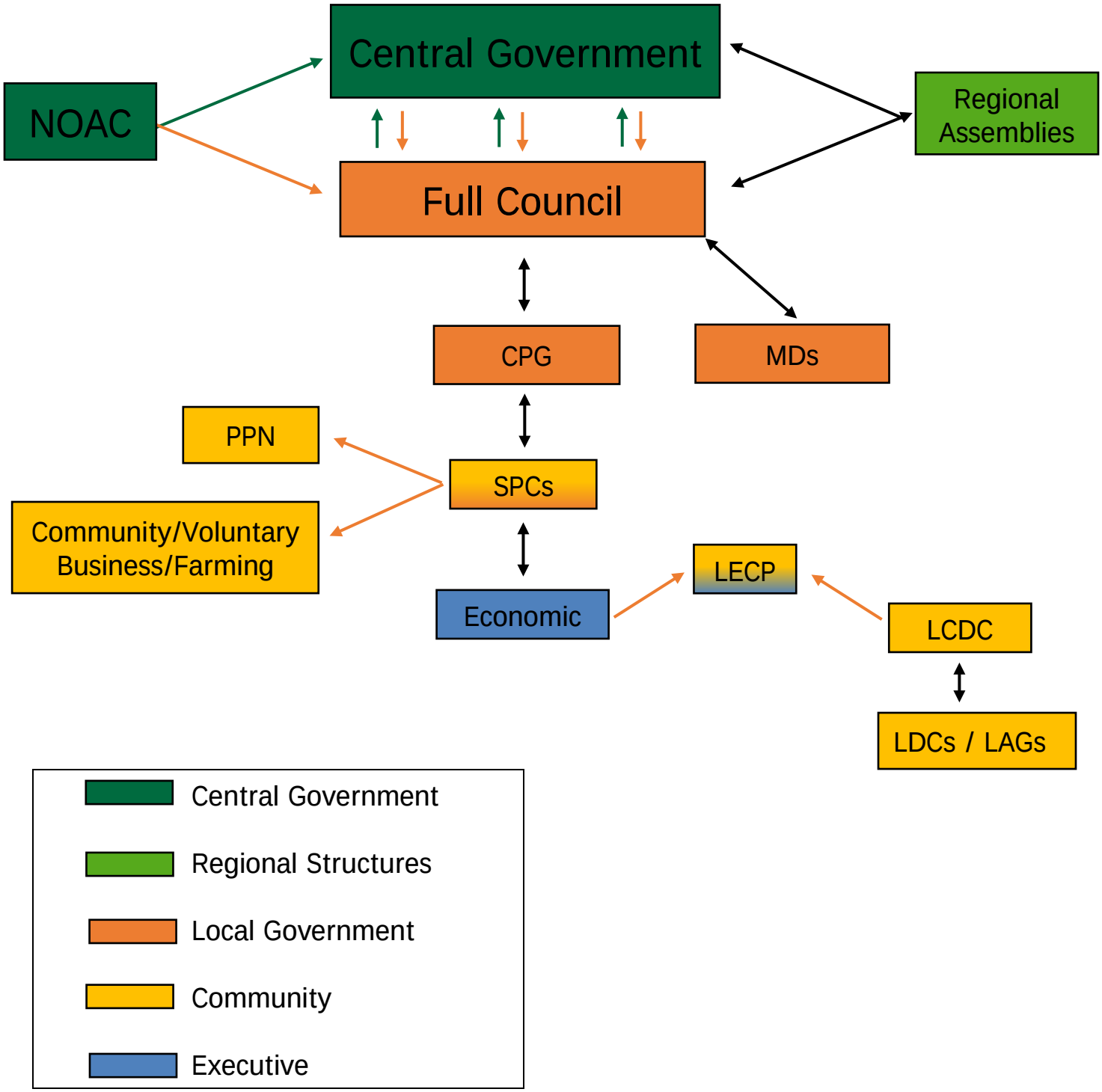
From the mid-1990s onwards, local government entered a period of ongoing reform. The structures and resources (staffing and financial) were developed by the Local Government Act 2001 to help meet the reasonable and genuine needs (and legitimate aspirations) of citizens. Partnership and citizen participation were encouraged and facilitated by the move towards integrating the local government and local development systems. In the context of the drive for greater public sector efficiencies and cost reductions post-2008, the Local Government Reform Act 2014 introduced the most fundamental *structural* changes in the history of Irish local government.

It is important to bear in mind, however, that local government, in the final analysis, is not about structures or procedures per se; fundamentally it is about people: citizens and customers living their lives in a quality environment. People should have opportunities to participate meaningfully in events which impact upon their lives. In addition, people deserve to live in an socially inclusive environment where communities can contribute to local development.

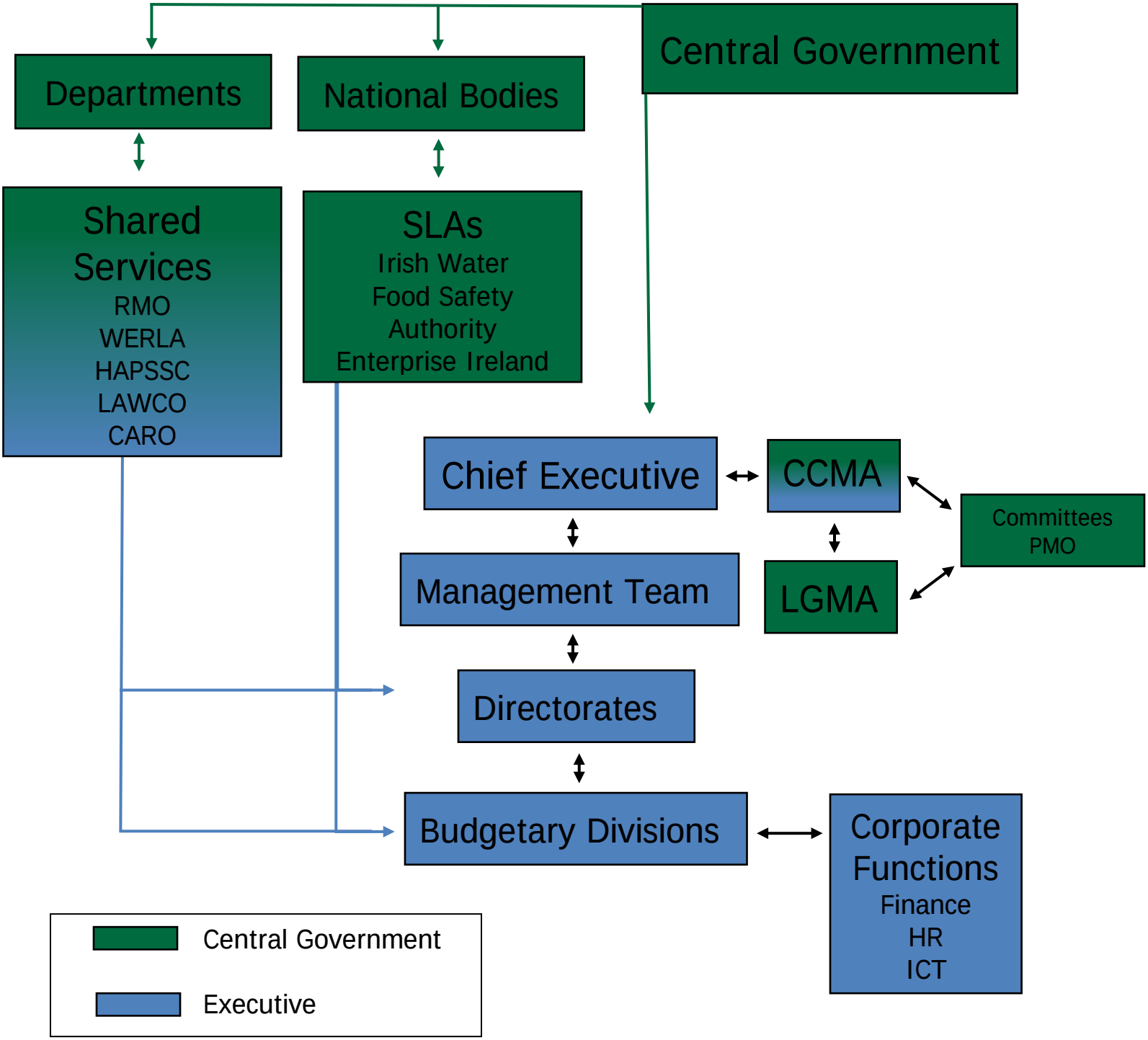
Students should always be cognisant of the "big picture" when considering the role and functions of individual departments within local authorities and their methods of operation. It is

also important to understand the role played by local government in the context of wider public services. Governments are formed by political parties who have been elected on their manifestos. These manifestos translate into 'Programmes for Government,' in effect the *corporate plan* for the lifetime of the government of the day. In this context, local government must compete for political and financial priority with other public services such as health, education, social protection, agriculture and so on.

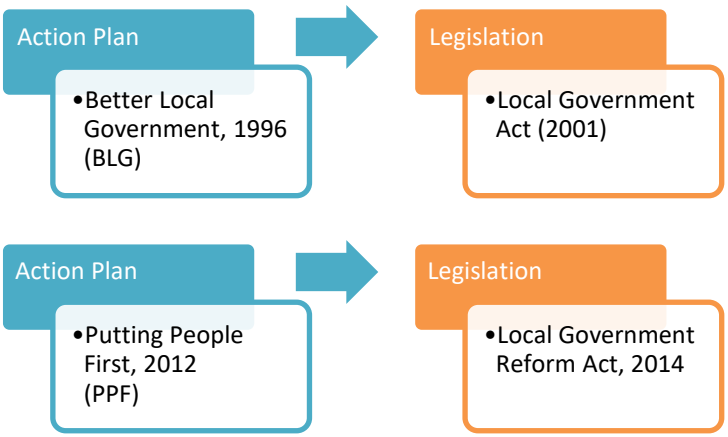
Political (reserved) Structure



Executive Schematic Structure



Developments from 1990s onwards can be expressed in a diagram, as below:



The following factors impact on reform:

- Political aspects—through the Programme for Government.
- Public expectations—through media and public representations.
- Financial constraints—where does the funding come?
- A dynamic society—through expectations of change.

2.0.1 Context and Early Reform – *Better Local Government: A Programme of Change* (1996) and the Local Government Act 2001.

'*Better Local Government*' was initiated as part of the wider Strategic Management Initiative (aimed at improving management across the public service) under the aegis of the Department of the Taoiseach. It was a codifying report borrowing many of its recommendations from previous documents, including the Barrington Report. It recommended increased roles for local government in education, health and economic matters. It also advocated that there be a better balance of power between the chief executive and elected members. It sought to strengthen the governance role of the councillors through establishing Strategic Policy Committees (SPCs). It recognised that new sources of funding were required, but it held that the overall the burden of tax should not increase. Many of its proposals were enacted through the Local Government Act of 2001.

Each local authority has a number of SPCs, usually between 4 and 5. These are statutory committees of the Council and their function is mainly to advise and assist on the formulation and amendment of policies. Each local authority has an SPC scheme, which must be approved by the elected members. This scheme includes details of the number of committees, their areas of function and their policy role. The membership of the committee is made up of 2/3 elected members and 1/3 external representation. External representation can be made up of Public

Participation Network (PPN), business interests, community and voluntary sector, etc. Details of the membership can be found on your local authority website.

2.1 PUTTING PEOPLE FIRST: ACTION PROGRAMME FOR EFFECTIVE LOCAL GOVERNMENT (2012) AND THE LOCAL GOVERNMENT REFORM ACT (2014)

2.1.1 *Putting People First* (2012)

A government action plan was launched in October 2012 entitled: '*Putting the People First: Action Programme for Effective Local Government*'. This action programme was to a large extent based on targets set out in the Programme for Government, 2011–16.

It is worthwhile to consider briefly some of the principles underpinning the then Minister for the Environment's (Minister Phil Hogan) political thinking on reform (taken from the Seanad debates of June and July 2012). The Minister held that:

- It is necessary to replace an outdated, dysfunctional system with what is needed for the 21st century.
- Public services should be delivered by locally based bodies.
- Local government will lead economic, social and community development.
- Previous devolution programmes were unrealistically ambitious.
- The local government funding base had been undermined since the late 1970s and thus could not promote mature, self-reliant local government.
- A rebalancing of power towards members and away from management was necessary.
- A far-reaching extension of local government's role to include transport, education and police should also be attempted, but as a longer-term project.

The vision enunciated for local government in the action plan was as follows:

> "It will be the main vehicle of governance and public service at local level-leading economic, social and community development delivering efficient and good value services, and representing citizens and local communities effectively and accountably".

To deliver on the aspirant vision the programme argued that there is a need for local authorities to be of a certain scale and have the human and financial resources to effect change. This vision sets a particular challenge to the local government system (as well as the wider public services) as a target towards which it should be aiming.

The action plan covered four main themes:

1. Structures.

2. Funding, Accountability and Governance.
3. Economic Development and Job Creation.
4. Delivering Services Efficiently.

Theme 1: Structures

- The number of local authorities (i.e. county and city councils and town councils) was reduced from 114 to 31. 80 town councils were dissolved and six local authorities were merged to form unitary authorities in Limerick, Waterford and Tipperary.

- The elected membership of local authorities was reduced from 1,627 to 949. It is worth noting that the membership of the primary units of local government, i.e. the county and city councils, increased from 883 to 949 members under the reform. The intention was that, generally, councils outside Dublin and Cork, including the amalgamated councils, would have a membership of not more than 40 councillors (The figure of 1:4,830 was used as a ratio of councillors per head of population as a benchmark in considering the number of councillors in any council (see Local Electoral Area Boundary Committee Report 2013)).

- To replace the dissolved town councils, a new unit of Municipal District was created. The intention was to centre each new municipal district round a town in as far as was possible to do so (particularly in areas that previously had town councils). By applying this new structure uniformly around the State (excluding the four Dublin authorities, Cork and Galway City Councils), there is now an equality of structure and treatment that previously had not applied (e.g. the County Limerick towns did not have any town councils previously even though towns with smaller populations in other counties did).

    - Municipal Districts focus on local/operational matters. That allows them to become quite responsive and accountable to local needs and to implement works at a local level or initiate planning for major schemes. The powers of the previous Town Councils had gradually been eroded over the years in any event and had moved to the county councils.
    - The new Municipal Districts had 45 specific functions assigned to them by the Local Government Reform Act 2014 (p. 217-224 of the Act), but these are quite modest in reach. So, in one sense, there was upward movement to the county level.
    - Budgets are decided at county level and have significant implications for the resources made available to Municipal Districts. Nonetheless, the Act also permits the Municipal District model to be strengthened by allowing the main council devolve a further 24 functions to the district level (at p.224-227 of the Act). This is a matter that can be decided at an individual county council level.
    - Over one hundred (113) of the major reserved functions remain exclusively to the main plenary council (making the annual budget, deciding to borrow money, requiring an act to be done and so on).

- At a regional level the 8 regional authorities and 2 regional assemblies were replaced by 3 regional assemblies. The membership was reduced from 290 to 83.

- The approach followed in Putting People First does raise the question of why the county has remained as the fundamental unit of local government, given the clear divergence in sizes, populations and resources. The 2012 Action Programme noted these divergences (at p. 45) but did not elaborate further on the limitations caused by same. The territorial reconfiguration was therefore restricted in terms of respecting county boundaries.

    - It is important to note that 6 local authorities merged to create three local authorities (in Limerick, Tipperary and Waterford).
    - Proposals to merge the two local authorities in Galway were under consideration during 2015-18 but were not pursued by government.
    - Cork City secured a large boundary extension incorporating a population increase of 85,000, which took effect under the Local Government Act 2019. This also made provision for financial arrangements and the transfer of staff and property from Cork County Council to Cork City Council.

Theme 2: Funding, Accountability and Governance

- Putting People First provided that local services administered by local authorities should be locally funded through an equitable property tax. This financial responsibility underpins local democratic decision-making. The programme argued that the Local Property Tax, which replaced the Household Charge and the Non-Principal Private Residence Charge, would provide a more sustainable and resilient system of funding for local authorities and therefore a sounder financial footing for the provision of essential local services. In Ireland there are two bodies with legal powers to tax, central and local government. The amount of tax raised locally (local property taxes and rates), while large in absolute terms, is small in relative terms to other streams of government income, thus affirming the degree of centralisation in this critical power. The introduction of the local property tax in 2013 restored a degree of fiscal autonomy to elected members for the first time since 1985.

- A new independently chaired National Oversight and Audit Commission for Local Government (NOAC) was established, involving external evaluation expertise. The NOAC provides an independent, high quality scrutiny of local government performance in fulfilling national, regional and local mandates. This is intended to strengthen governance. NOAC's statutory functions under section 61 of the Local Government Reform Act 2014 include:

- "scrutinise performance of any local government body against relevant indicators as selected by NOAC (to include customer service) or as prescribed in Ministerial regulations;
- scrutinise financial performance, including value for money, of any local government body in respect of its financial resources
- support best practice (development and enhancement) in the performance by local government bodies
- monitor and evaluate adherence to service level agreements entered into by any local government body
- oversee how national local government policy is implemented by local authorities
- evaluate public service reform implementation by any local authority
- monitor adequacy of corporate plans prepared by regional assemblies and councils and evaluate implementation of the plans by any local government body or generally;
- carry out any additional functions conferred by Ministerial order."

- Local Authority Audit Committees were placed on a full statutory footing and the Committee's review of the local government auditor's report are included in its report to the Council. This is intended to strengthen governance.

- The position of Local Authority Manager was replaced by a Chief Executive (CE) post. This was not a simple change in title. The CE is required to implement the policies of the Council and to report formally on a monthly basis on the performance of the executive in delivering services. The change in title and reporting arrangements is intended to make the CE and staff more accountable for the performance of their functions. This would include the deployment and use of resources to meet the objectives of the Council's Corporate Plan. Please refer to your own local authority website for copies of these reports, which are available to the public.

- Reserved functions of elected members were strengthened. For example, the power to vary the Local Property Tax, the appointment of the Chief Executive (see Section 145 of the 2014 Act), the power to adopt an annual service delivery plan.

- In furtherance of increased governance for members, the Chief Executive can be required to report to the Council on the implementation of any policy. If the members regard the report or conduct of the executive as unsatisfactory, they can adopt a statement setting out their objections. This power can also be seen against another new function given to members to adopt a service delivery plan, setting goals (aligned to the Council's Corporate Plan) and the level and standard of services expected. Thus, viewed generally, the 2014 Act moved to strengthen the role of the elected Council and secure higher levels of public participation and accountability in the locality.

- In efforts to encourage the members to function more as a collective unit of government and move away from the characteristic clientelist role, the right that members previously

enjoyed to pass a Section 140 resolution, directing the Chief Executive to carry out a particular function, was removed in relation to planning matters or any matter involving financial benefit to an individual or organization.

Theme 3. Economic Development and Job Creation

- Putting People First (PPF) gave an enhanced role in economic development and enterprise support to local authorities. A new *dedicated* SPC for economic development was created in each local authority and a specific Director of Services for economic development was appointed. This SPC is responsible for preparing the economic element of the Local Economic and Community Plan (LECP).

- A key outcome of PPF was the integration of Local Enterprise Offices (LEOs) with local authority business support units to create a one-stop-shop for business support. This was a major vote of confidence in the sector.

- A key objective of PPF was the closer alignment of local and community development supports with local government (these areas of economic development and local community development are briefly expanded on below and are dealt with in more detail in the Lesson dedicated to this area).

Theme 4: Delivering Services Efficiently

- Implementation of recommendations of the Local Government Efficiency Review Implementation Group and the Local Authority Workforce Planning Process yielded significant savings (see for example *Local Government Efficiency Review Reforms*, NOAC Report no. 5, 2016). A key part of public sector and local government reform is modernisation. This includes investing in technological solutions, specialist recruitment and determining the workforce of the future. These strategic aims are designed to position local government as a leader in public service delivery. Key themes outlined in the Local Government People Strategy (which can be accessed on the Local Government Management Agency (LGMA) website) include:

    - Workforce of the Future – reflecting how increased public expectations, emerging government priorities and alternative service delivery models may impact on future workforce needs.
    - Capacity and Capability – reflecting on how local government can attract, recruit and retain people with the appropriate knowledge, skills and behaviours.
    - A Culture of Continuous Learning and Development – developing learning and development plana in line with corporate priorities and career development

- Shared service initiatives were progressed across a range of areas—e.g. Core Payroll (Laois County Council), Housing Assistance Programme (HAP) (Limerick City and County Council), Building Control Management System (BCMS), eReturns, MyPay, Treasury, FixYourStreet,

Road Management Office (Donegal and Cork), Waste Enforcement Regional Lead Authorities (WERLA-Regionalised), Local Authority Waters and Communities Office (LAWCO) (Clonmel), Debt Management, Climate Action Regional Offices (CAROs) , Service Catalogue, Age Friendly Ireland, and Rural Water. The net result of these changes is to release resources – human and financial – for the provision of necessary front-line services in local areas.

- Local authorities are now required to provide good quality public information, particularly in relation to local services and resource utilisation. Every year the local authorities prepare an Annual Service Plan (ASP) with specific actions and targets and the resources they need to facilitate comparison of output against approved budget at year end. The ASP must be adopted by the elected members and is a subset of the Corporate Plan.

- Service Level Agreements (SLAs) have been developed between government departments and local authorities. For example, Uisce Éireann, the Food Safety Authority of Ireland and Enterprise Ireland (LEOs).

- As a result of improved management, *Putting People First* identified over €830 million in total savings achieved from 2008 to 2013. NOAC by 2016 identified annual efficiencies and savings implemented during the 2010 to 2016 period as amounting to some €586 million per year. These savings were achieved at a time of economic recession and represented a very material contribution by the local government sector to national recovery at that time. This demonstrated the important contribution that reform in the local government sector can make to the nation. It emphasises the need for continuous effort in the management of resources.

2.1.2 Local Government Reform Act 2014

The Local Government Reform Act, 2014 which became law on in January 2014, made legal provision for many of the reforms set out in the government's *Putting People First: Action Programme for Effective Local Government*. It gave legislative power to many of its recommendations.

The Government argued that the outcome of these reforms has created a local government system that is dynamic, fit for purpose and makes full use of its resources, capacity and potential to play as wide a role as possible in public service and administration, not only in the service areas that have been the sector's main focus but also in contributing to national recovery and economic growth.

2.2 REGIONAL ASSEMBLIES

The 8 Regional Authorities that had existed prior to 2014 were dissolved with effect from June 2014 and their functions, staff, liabilities, assets, etc., were transferred to either the Border, Midlands, Western or the Southern and Eastern Regional Assembly. Three new Regional Assemblies were established from January 2015.

The Regional Assembly consists of members drawn from their constituent local authorities within the region as follows:

- The Northern and Western Regional Assembly includes the county councils of Cavan, Donegal, Leitrim, Galway, Mayo, Monaghan, Roscommon, Sligo, along with Galway city.
- The Southern Regional Assembly includes the county councils of Carlow, Clare, Cork, Kerry, Kilkenny, Tipperary and Wexford, along with Cork city and Limerick and Waterford city and county councils.
- The Eastern and Midland Regional Assembly includes the county councils of Dun Laoghaire-Rathdown, Fingal, Kildare, Laois, Longford, Louth, Meath, Offaly, South Dublin, Westmeath and Wicklow, along with Dublin city.

The aim of the regional assemblies is to:

- Adopt regional spatial and economic strategies (RSES). These replaced the previous regional planning guidelines and were drawn up in conjunction with the various enterprise and economic development agencies.
- Co-ordinate, promote or support strategic planning and sustainable development.
- Promote effectiveness in local government and public services in conjunction with NOAC.

2.3 ALIGNMENT OF LOCAL GOVERNMENT AND LOCAL DEVELOPMENT

Recommendations for the greater alignment of local government and local development systems were presented in the Final Report of the Local Government / Local Development Alignment Steering Group, and incorporated as part of the *Putting People First* programme (2012). The recommendations were aimed at:

- providing a more central co-ordinating role for local government in local and community development
- achieving greater efficiency and effectiveness in local and community development programming
- improving the delivery of services for citizens and communities.

Legislation underpinning these recommendations came into effect in 2014 with the commencement of Part 6 of the Local Government Reform Act, 2014.

2.3.1 Local Community Development Committees (LCDC)

Part 6 of the Local Government Reform Act, 2014 provided for the establishment of Local Community Development Committees in each local authority area to enhance the strategic planning and coordination of local and community development activity. Local Community Development Committees comprise public and private sector members, including local authority members and officials, state agencies and private sector local and community development representatives.

Working in partnership, they are required to:

- Prepare the community elements of a 6-year Local Economic and Community Plan (LECP).
- Coordinate, manage and oversee the implementation of local and community development programmes as part of implementing the LECP.
- Coordinate generally local and community development activity within the operational area of the Local Community Development Committee (LCDC) for the purposes of reducing overlap, avoiding duplication and improving the targeting of resources.

Further details on both the LCDC and LECP are provided in the Lesson on Economic and Local Development.

2.3.2 Economic Development & Enterprise Role

Local authorities have always had an economic role. This role, however, was largely informal and to some extent seen as discretionary. Furthermore, it was not recognised at Departmental level and was never measured. Traditionally, other organisations—including County / City Enterprise Boards, Local Development Committees, Enterprise Ireland (EI) and the Industrial Development Authority (IDA)—operated within the economic development sphere in a formal capacity. This led to a somewhat fragmented approach to economic development. Following the Local Government Reform Act 2014, local authorities were given a more explicit and dynamic role in economic development and enterprise. This is seen as a key growth area of local government along with other areas of work such as climate change.

To facilitate this:

- A dedicated SPC for Economic Development and Enterprise was set up in all local authorities to have oversight of all economic development and enterprise policy in the area. It develops appropriate economic policies which fall within the local authority's remit.

- The Local Economic & Community Plan (LECP) is intended to highlight the key economic policy areas that the local authority and the various economic sectors working in the area must address. The reform element here is the partial decentralisation of decision-making for economic development through "a bottom-up approach".
- The enterprise elements of the Rural Development Programme (RDP) must be aligned with the LCDC and the LECP
- County / City Enterprise Boards were merged with the economic units of the local authority to form Local Enterprise Offices (LEOs)

2.3.3 Local Enterprise Offices (LEOs)

LEOs were launched in 2012 as 'One Stop Shops' for enterprise supports, designed to build upon on the significant work done by the County / City Enterprise Boards. A Micro Enterprise and Small Business Unit in Enterprise Ireland (EI) was created to work with local authorities to establish the network of Local Enterprise Offices (LEOs) in each authority. The LEOs are mandated to provide a range of supports and services to all local micro enterprises (initially companies with fewer than 10 employees but in 2023 extended to companies employing up to 50 employees) who seek such supports.

Further details on both the economic development and enterprise support role and the work of LEOs is provided in the Lesson on Economic and Local Development.

2.4 PUBLIC PARTICIPATION NETWORKS (PPNs)

Section 46 of the Local Government Reform Act, 2014 states that: "A local authority may take such steps as it considers appropriate to consult with and promote effective participation by the local community in local government". This section provided the legislative basis for the establishment of the Public Participation Networks (PPNs) to facilitate greater collaboration between Local Authorities and local volunteer-led organisations.

Public Participation Networks (PPNs): A User Guide was issued in May 2016. The intention was that the PPN would be an important framework that enabled the public take a much more active role in local authority committees. From the local authority's perspective, there is now a formal mechanism in place that allows it to connect with community & voluntary, social inclusion and environmental sectors in a more much effective manner. The PPN is a mechanism by which the community and voluntary sector nominate persons to be members of the local authority's SPCs, as well as other structures such as LCDCs and joint policing committees. In turn, these members report back to the PPN.

Further information on PPNs is provided in the Lesson on Economic and Local Development.

2.5 EDUCATION & TRAINING BOARDS (ETBs)

The passing of the Education and Training Boards Act, 2013 brought further change to the local government sector. Vocational Education Committees (VECs) were previously structured along the local authority administrative areas and were tasked with establishing and maintaining a suitable system of education. From July 2013, however, the 33 VECs were formally dissolved and replaced by 16 Education and Training Boards (ETBs).

The purpose of each ETB is to bring about a better level of coordination and delivery of education and training at a local level. ETBs manage and operate second-level schools, further education colleges, pilot community national schools and a range of adult and further education centres delivering education and training programmes. Local councils may nominate a specified number of the Councillors to serve as members of the ETB covering their area.

2.6 DIRECTLY ELECTED MAYORS

The government published policy proposals in 2018 for directly elected mayors with executive functions. The first step in this process was a plebiscite, and this was given legislative effect in the Local Government Act 2019. The plebiscites were a process to gauge the public's view on the proposal and were confined by the Act to Cork City, and Limerick and Waterford City and County Councils.

Under proposals published by the Department, a directly elected mayor with executive functions would:

- prepare and oversee implementation of a programme of office (similar to a programme for government)
- perform a significant amount of the executive functions currently performed by local authority chief executives
- ensure that the chief executive performs the functions of the local authority in accordance with the mayor and elected council's policies
- be an ex-officio member and Cathaoirleach of the elected council, contributing to the elected council's exercise of their reserved functions
- represent the entire local authority area at local, national and international level.

As a result of the Act, in May 2019 the people of Cork city, Limerick city and county, and Waterford city and county had an opportunity to vote in a plebiscite on the topic. These plebiscites were held in conjunction with the 2019 local elections. Voters in Cork City and Waterford City and County rejected proposals for a directly elected mayor. Limerick voters passed the plebiscite and, on this basis, the Government provided for the establishment of this office under the Local Government (Mayor of Limerick) and Miscellaneous Provisions Act 2024. In June 2024, voters in Limerick city and county made history by electing John Moran as Ireland's

first directly-elected mayor. Limerick is widely seen as a test-case for the idea – depending on the experience, it may be a model extended to other areas.

Students should note that the topic of directly elected mayors has been debated for many years in Ireland. Previous attempts to introduce the position in Dublin were unsuccessful in 2014, as the four local authorities in Dublin did not have unanimous agreement. Fingal County Council refused to endorse the Government's proposal. Since then, the Government established a Citizen's Assembly on a directly-elected mayor for Dublin in 2022 which reported in 2023, recommending that a directly-elected mayor for Dublin city and county be established which would work alongside the existing four Dublin local authorities, but that these new arrangements should also be accompanied by a significant devolution of functions from central government and state agencies.

2.7 CONCLUSION

The information set out above shows that local government has undergone material structural and systemic change since 2014. In the aftermath of the economic recession from 2008 onwards, local authorities reduced their revenue and capital spending quite significantly and decreased their staffing compliments more than any other sector within the public service. They did so to assist with national recovery at a time when the economic independence of the State was compromised. Local authorities have embraced shared services, contributed to employment growth and economic development at a time when it was badly needed. During the Covid-19 pandemic, local government was also at the forefront in adapting services, setting up local community response forums and local helplines, and working with the voluntary sector to mobilise local responses to the pandemic, for example to provide assistance to the elderly or other voluntary groups during lockdowns. During this period, the local government sector demonstrated a high degree of flexibility in its structures, funding, service delivery and strategies. The way public services are planned and implemented continues to change and evolve in response to changes in the way we do business. Technology alone will force the pace of change, as well other pressures in wider society, from climate change to economic pressures.

Enhanced responsibilities in the realm of community and economic development have shifted the parameters within which local authorities now operate. In the context of *Putting People First* and the continuing reform agenda, it is undoubtedly an interesting time to be part of local government as it seeks to move closer to the communities that it serves. Such change is driven by demand for greater community engagement and public accountability. It has also been driven by the need to sustain the democratic processes and structures that are the foundations of the Republic.

The plans, actions, finances and decision-making processes of local authorities are open to public scrutiny and are subject of much media and public attention. It is fair to say that local government is no longer a mere provider of services. Its wider role in building communities, fostering social inclusion, promoting economic development, enhancing participatory

democracy and encouraging involvement in civic life is very evident. This is the intention of the modernisation agenda that is delivering contemporary local government reform.

The challenge is to achieve this in the context of sustainable economic growth, anticipated significant population increases (under the National Planning Framework), social change (referenda on marriage equality and the repealing of the Eighth Amendment), inward multinational migration, social integration and increased cultural diversity, the need to mitigate and adapt to climate change, and coping with accelerating technological developments in areas such as communications and artificial intelligence.

As the Irish economy has recovered after both the recession in the years after 2008 and the Covid-19 pandemic in the years after 2020, local government is faced with addressing infrastructural shortcomings in housing, roads and public transport. There is also a clear increased public awareness of the impacts of climate change. Local government has an important role to play in addressing these matters and seeking to deliver on the necessary societal changes.

KEY CONCEPTS

- Devolution of Functions
- Subsidiarity
- Barrington Report
- Better Local Government
- Putting People First
- Corporate Policy Group (CPG)
- Strategic Policy Committees (SPCs)
- Municipal Districts
- Public Participation Network (PPN)
- Local Community Development Committees (LCDCs)
- Local Enterprise Offices (LEOs)
- Local Economic and Community Plan (LECP)
- Education and Training Boards (ETBs)
- Directly-Elected Mayors
- Regional Assemblies
- Local Property Tax (LPT)
- National Oversight and Audit Commission (NOAC)

APPENDIX 1

A LIST OF PAST ATTEMPTS AT LOCAL GOVERNMENT REFORM

The basic structure of local government in Ireland as set out in the Local Government (Ireland) Act, 1898 remained remarkably intact until relatively recently. This Appendix lists historical reform proposals for the sector since 1970. It is often useful to look at historical reform proposals to see how often these have been made, whether they were implemented at all, and how long it took to do so.

Below is a list of some of the reports in the area of Local Government Reform since 1970. For detail on many of these reports, please consult chapter 2 of Mark Callanan (ed.,) *Local Government in the Republic of Ireland* (IPA, Dublin, 2018).

- White Paper on Local Government Re-Organisation, 1971.
- Strengthening the Local Government Service – McKinsey Report, 1971
- White Paper on Local Finance and Taxation, 1972
- Local Government Re-Organisation – Discussion Document 1973
- The Reform of Local Government, a Policy Statement 1985
- Local Government Reorganisation and Reform, 1991 – Barrington Report
- The Financing of Local Authorities – The National Economic and Social Council, 1995
- Study on Local Government Finance – KPMG Management Consulting, 1996
- Towards Cohesive Local Government, 1996
- Devolution Commission – Reports; 1996, 1997
- Better Local Government - A Programme for Change, 1996
- Review of Local Government Financing- Indecon Report, 2006
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